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RETURN OF THE FAIL-SAFE

With the 2027 Asian Cup qualifiers approaching, Sunil Chhetri had to be recalled in order to **resolve the crisis** crippling the Indian attack.

ISL



Not many months ago, Sunil Chhetri (**above**) brought the curtain down on his international football career. The much-celebrated Indian football captain said the decision was prompted by his 'instincts', which may have told him that he had achieved enough in almost two decades of his association with the senior men's national football team.

Around 59,000 people turned up at the Salt Lake Stadium in the first week of June 2024 to see the 39-year-old legend walking into the sunset following a goalless draw against Kuwait. Emotional scenes unfolded at the venue as a tearful Chhetri accepted the adulations of his teammates and fans with folded hands before returning to the Indian dressing room for the last time.

Eight months later, Chhetri, who

has scored 94 goals in 151 appearances for the country, had to fetch his scoring boots back from the hanger as the current national coach, Manolo Marquez, literally came knocking at his door with an SOS message.

Manolo, who assumed charge of the national team last July following the exit of Igor Stimac, saw the Indian side struggle for goals in the few international matches it played under his coaching. And with the 2027 Asian Cup qualifiers approaching, Chhetri had to be recalled in order to resolve the crisis crippling the Indian attack.

"This is the reason that I spoke to him (Sunil) personally because it is a difficult situation for the Indian team. In my four games with the national team, we scored just two goals. We need to score more goals, and we need immediate results," Manolo

said.

"At this moment, Sunil is the best Indian striker. He is the top goalscorer among the Indian players in the Indian Super League (ISL) — 12 goals so far for his club, Bengaluru FC — and the team now needs players who can score goals," Manolo said in support of his decision to persuade the 40-year-old striker to end his retirement.

Amitabha Das Sharma

Fortune reversal

Memory is a fickle element in football. A couple of penalty saves makes you Hercules, and the next goal sets you up as a court jester.

About a year ago, when Chennaiyin FC played NorthEast United FC, the gates were flooded with blue shirts, nearly 7,000 of them, chanting slogans for Owen Coyle and his army at the Jawaharlal